MAKI Tagging — Quick Guide

Each tag answers a distinct question about the photo. Carry one from each facet; intersect in search.

Principles

rules that keep the tag catalogue coherent over years

1. Tag in hierarchies. Separator is `|`. Ancestors auto-expand: `subject|nature|landscape` also stores `subject|nature` and `subject`.

2. Generic lowercase, proper nouns keep case. `concert` not `Concert`; `Peter Schneider` stays capitalised; `Germany` in English but `München` local.

3. One language. Pick one and stick with it. Place names: English for countries, local from region down.

4. Facets are orthogonal. Independent axes, not nested. Intersect in queries; don't mash into one tree.

5. Tag what you see. Primary tags describe visible content; context goes in secondary tags.

6. Don't duplicate metadata. Camera, lens, date, GPS are EXIF; folders are path. Don't tag them.

7. Aim for 5−15 tags per image. Fewer is poor discoverability; more is usually noise.

8. Separate workflow from content. Ratings / color labels / saved searches for state. Tags for content.

The Facets

one question per axis — any photo can carry a tag from each

What is in the image?

```
subject|nature|landscape
subject|animal|bird
subject|urban|architecture
subject|person|portrait
subject|performing arts|concert
subject|event|wedding
subject|object|food
subject|mood|dramatic
```

Which specific occasion?

```
event|wedding-jane-2025
event|fuji-trip-2023
event|workshop-la-2019
```

Date-driven, grows unboundedly. Flat naming or `event|2025|...`. Separate from `subject|event|*`, which is the generic scene type.

Where was it taken?

```
location|Germany
location|Germany|Bayern
location|Germany|Bayern|München
location|Germany|Bayern|
  Gelting|Kulturbühne Hinterhalt
```

Countries in English; local names from region down.

Who is in it?

```
person|family
person|friend|Alice Müller
person|artist|musician|
  Peter Schneider
person|ensemble|band|
  Alice Viola Trio
```

For large catalogues, consider face recognition instead of manual person tags.

How was it made?

```
technique|style|black and white
technique|lighting|golden hour
technique|lighting|stage lighting
technique|exposure|long exposure
technique|composition|symmetry
technique|effect|bokeh
```

Which project/assignment?

```
project|365 pictures 2018
project|Bricking Bavaria
project|Workshop LA 2019
```

Purely personal.
Names are proper nouns; keep original case.

Dominant content colour?

```
color|red  color|blue
color|warm  color|cold
color|monochrome
color|pastel  color|muted
```

Keep flat.
Content colour is different from MAKI's editorial color-label field (5 fixed values).

Ask: what distinct question does this answer?

- New question → **top-level facet**.
- Refines an existing axis → **nest it**.
- Date-driven instance (weddings, trips) → top-level.
- Visual property (colour, tone) → top-level.
- Nameable & scoped (projects) → top-level.

Facets are cheap to add; wrong nesting is expensive to fix later.

One photo, many facets

a photo from Jane's 2025 wedding reception

A single photo can intersect every facet. Each tag answers a different question about the same image:

`subject|event|wedding`	*scene type*
`subject|person|group`	*composition*
`subject|mood|joyful`	*mood*
`event|wedding-jane-2025`	*specific occasion*
`location|Germany|Bayern|München`	*where*
`person|friend|Alice M.`	*who*
`technique|lighting|golden hour`	*how lit*
`technique|style|documentary`	*how shot*
`color|warm`	*dominant colour*

9 leaf tags across 7 facets. With ancestor expansion, ~15 tags stored. Search "`event:wedding-jane-2025 person:Alice color:warm`" intersects three orthogonal axes.

Three places for event-related tags

three different questions, three different tags — they coexist on the same photo

`subject|performing arts|concert`	photo *depicts a performance*
`subject|event|wedding`	photo *depicts a ceremony / gathering*
`event|wedding-jane-2025`	photo *is from this specific occasion*

A wedding photo can carry both `subject|event|wedding` and `event|wedding-jane-2025`. A concert photo fits under `subject|performing arts|concert`, not `subject|event|*`.

Tag commands

CLI and web UI share the same operations and the same semantics

`maki tag ID foo bar`	Add tags (ancestors auto-expanded).
`maki tag ID --remove foo`	Remove tags (orphaned ancestors cleaned).
`maki tag clear ID`	Remove all tags from an asset.
`maki tag rename OLD NEW --apply`	Rename a tag everywhere. Cascades to descendants.
`maki tag delete TAG --apply`	Delete a tag (and descendants) from every asset.
`maki tag split OLD A B... --apply`	Replace one tag with multiple (variadic).
`... --keep`	Keep source alongside (additive / copy).
`maki tag expand-ancestors --apply`	Backfill ancestor paths on existing tags.
`maki tag fix-unicode --apply`	NFC-normalise tag values; merges NFC/NFD duplicates.
`maki tag export-vocabulary`	Export the tag tree as `vocabulary.yaml`.
`... --default`	Export the built-in starter vocabulary (ignores catalogue).
`... --format text`	Tab-indented file for Lightroom / Capture One keyword import.

`tag:landscape`	Tag match at any level (default).
`tag:=landscape`	Whole-path match (exact tag value).
`tag:/landscape`	Leaf only at any level.
`tag:^Landscape`	Case-sensitive.
`tag:|wed`	Prefix anchor (`wedding`, `wedding-...`).
`-tag:rejected`	Exclude.
`tag:a,b`	Either `a` or `b`.
`tag:a tag:b`	Both `a` and `b`.
`event:jane person:Alice color:warm`	Intersect three facets.

Same filters work in CLI `maki search` and in the web UI search box.

MAKI
Media Asset Keeper & Indexer

https://maki-dam.com/ — *full details in the Tagging Guide chapter of the manual*